

The MVP Scope Canvas

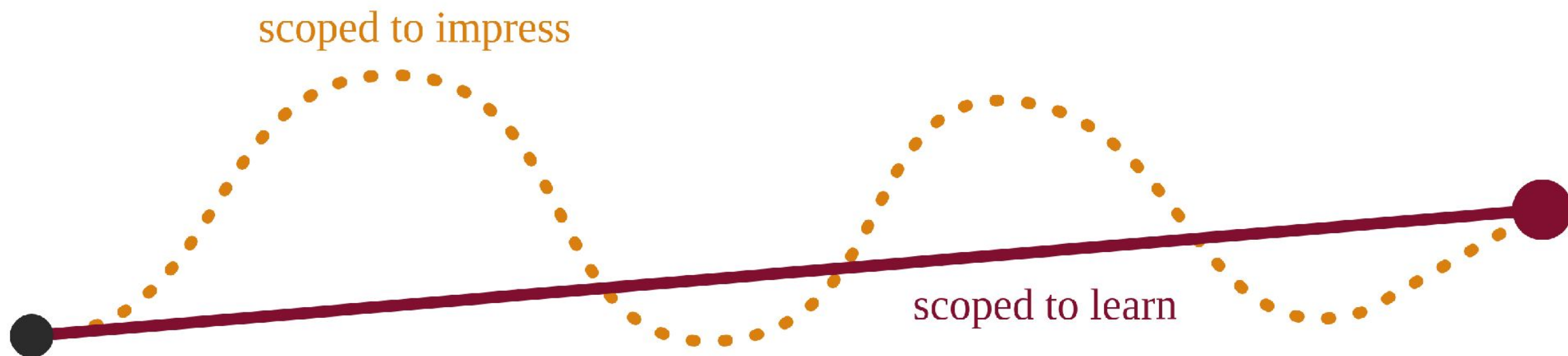
Keep cutting until only the question is left.

Zohare Haider · Misk Launchpad 10.0, Phase 1 · 16 September 2026

Most MVPs are built to be admired.

The winners are the fastest, cheapest & quickest

The difference costs about a year (or so). Trust me, I went through it.



WHY LISTEN TO ME

Built. Backed. Still building.

BUILT

foona.net, digital.st and jalebi.io: three ventures I founded over two decades, Pakistan to the Gulf. Plus microdrip.pk, built with Acumen.org as venture architect, and business lines across telco, education and tech.

BACKED

Angel in Tropicfeel, Mous, blueflite, CrossVal, .dodocs.ai, RAPTR and Mappa. I've judged pitches from the side of the table you're trying to win.

BUILDING

CrossVal today: financial clarity for GCC founders, so you see what's working before the runway runs out.



Zohare Haider

Retired founder. Active builder.

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WHY LISTEN TO ME

I built the right thing, but slowly & expensively

PREVIOUSLY

jalebi.io, an operating system for food and beverage.



Started in 2021



Techstars. Hub71. STC. 35 Angels.



Deloitte Fast 50. UAE Future100. Majra Gold Seal.



Wound down in 2025

NOW



Growth at CrossVal, an AI accountant for UAE SMEs.



Advising and Boards of various startups



Mentoring fifteen teams in this cohort for MiSK

“I am not here to tell you what worked.

I am here to tell you what I built and how it can end poorly.”

When did a real customer last touch what you are currently building?

This week

This month

Longer ago

Never

The rest of this hour can shorten that gap.

Two lists. Only one ships value.

What we built

A dashboard nobody opened

Three integrations before one customer

A Saudi entity, because investors asked

Settings, permissions, an admin panel

A third country, to close a deal

The left list took 11 months.

What we needed to learn

Will one operator pay for this at all?

Is the problem real or a symptom of another?

What do they use instead today?

What would make them stop using us?

The right list needs 6 conversations.

ONE PAGE, SIX CELLS

The MVP Scope Canvas

01

One user

A person you could email today.

02

One job

Their words. No product name.

03

Riskiest assumption

The one that, if wrong, kills it.

04

Smallest killing test

Cheapest way to be proven wrong.

05

Kill number and date

Written before the test runs.

06

The not-list

What you refuse to build.

Cells 3 and 5 do the work.

————— *They are the ones you are most likely to skip.*

One user, named

A person you could email today.

TOO VAGUE

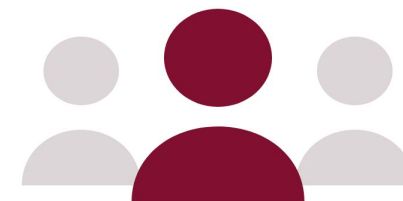
“Small and medium businesses in Saudi Arabia.”

SPECIFIC ENOUGH TO BE WRONG

“The operations manager of a 3 to 8 branch restaurant group in Riyadh.”

WHY IT MATTERS

Picture one face. If you cannot, you won't be able to interview them, and you will never know if they will say 'YES'.



One job

Their words. No product name.

TOO VAGUE

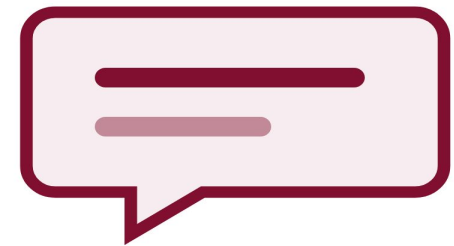
“They need better analytics and visibility.”

SPECIFIC ENOUGH TO BE WRONG

“I want to know on Monday what last week actually cost me to operate.”

WHY IT MATTERS

Write it in their language. Don't crowd it with your product name.



Riskiest assumption

The one that, if wrong, kills it.

TOO VAGUE

“We assume we can build it.”

SPECIFIC ENOUGH TO BE WRONG

“We assume they will pay rather than keep using the spreadsheet.”

WHY IT MATTERS

Teams die because nobody wanted it enough to pay. The code almost always worked.



Smallest killing test

Cheapest way to be proven wrong.

TOO VAGUE

“Launch the platform and see.”

SPECIFIC ENOUGH TO BE WRONG

“Ten paid pilots at any price, run by hand, no product at all.”

WHY IT MATTERS

A real test can come back negative. Design yours so it can.



Kill number and date

Written before the test runs.

TOO VAGUE

"We will review how it goes and see."

SPECIFIC ENOUGH TO BE WRONG

"Fewer than 4 / 10 convert by 31 October and we stop."

WHY IT MATTERS

Write the number before the test runs.



The not-list

What you refuse to build.

TOO VAGUE

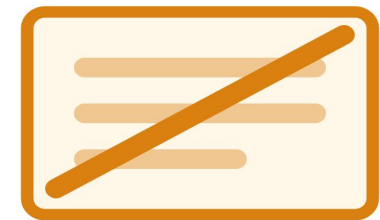
"We are focused on the core product."

SPECIFIC ENOUGH TO BE WRONG

"No mobile app. No integrations. No second country.
Not this quarter."

WHY IT MATTERS

Say it out loud to the team. Otherwise, it is only
an intention.



jalebi, year one, as I should have written it

- 01 Faisal, who owns four Dubai cafes and checks stock by walking into the storeroom on a Sunday.
- 02 “I want to know on Monday what last week actually cost me.”
- 03 That he will pay for the number. He has survived on guesswork for nine years.
- 04 Ten venues. I count their stock by hand for four weeks. No software.
- 05 Fewer than 4 of 10 renew by 30 November, and I stop.
- 06 No POS integration. No procurement module. No second country.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED

I skipped 3 and 5, then lost 6

Never tested whether they would pay. I assumed it.

Never wrote a kill number, so nothing ever tripped.

Built the POS integration because one customer asked loudly.

Opened a second market before the first one paid for itself.

11

months of build before the first honest no

What I built



What would have told me



month 11

Every line of it worked. None of it answered the question.

Your turn. Eight minutes.

Six cells. Your company. Cameras off if you prefer.

Run out of time? Cells 03 and 05 carry the weight. The riskiest assumption,
and the number that stops you.

TWENTY MINUTES, TWO VOLUNTEERS

Let's pull one apart on screen

WHAT I WILL ASK, IN THIS ORDER

- 1 Could you email the person in cell 1 tonight? What is their name?
- 2 Read cell 2 back to me without saying your product name.
- 3 If cell 3 turns out to be false, is the company over? If not, it isn't your riskiest. Now you get it?
- 4 Could cell 4 come back negative? Walk me through what that looks like.
- 5 Say the number in cell 5 out loud, then tell me the date beside it.
- 6 Read me cell 6. Who on your team has heard that list?

Three ways scope climbs back in

1

An investor question

Somebody asks whether you have thought about enterprise.

By Friday it sits on the roadmap.

Nobody asked you to build it.

2

One loud customer

Your biggest logo asks for one thing. You build it.

Now you have a consultancy with one client and a product nobody else fits.

3

A hire needing work

You hire an engineer in March.

By April they need something to own, and a new feature is the easiest thing to hand them.

You write the not-list once.

You defend it every week after.

WHY THIS IS DUE NOW

The canvas is Assignment 2

It asks for an MVP roadmap and a product vision.

A roadmap with no kill criteria is a wish list, and any mentor worth their salt can tell.

Cells 1 and 2 Who it is for, and the job. Your vision statement comes straight out of these.

Cells 3 and 4 What you will test in Phase 2, and how. The roadmap's first milestone.

Cells 5 and 6 The kill criteria and the boundary. What separates a roadmap from a wish list.

Fill the canvas honestly tonight and spend the remaining time enjoying an iced latte.

ONE ASK BEFORE YOU GO

Post your kill number and its date
in the cohort group by Friday.

A number nobody else has seen is a note to self, so be honest with yourself.

Questions are in Slido. I will work through them now, and answer the rest in writing
after the session.